

Count me in Peter. I had thought/hoped that this conspiracy stuff would fade, but clearly not. So yes, I agree it's time to actively counter it, and express peer support for the world class Chinese scientists doing such great work, yet being publicly and professionally impugned.

Well done mate.
Hume

Hume Field BVSc MSc PhD MACVS
Honorary Professor | **University of Queensland** | Australia
Science & Policy Advisor | **EcoHealth Alliance** | USA
Director | **Jeppesen Field Consulting** | Australia.

Ph: +61448582311

From: Peter Daszak <daszak@ecohealthalliance.org>
Sent: Thursday, 6 February 2020 3:44 PM
To: Ralph Baric (rbaric@email.unc.edu) <rbaric@email.unc.edu>; Saif, Linda <saif.2@osu.edu>;
jmhughe@emory.edu; Rita Colwell <rcolwell@umiacs.umd.edu>; rcolwell@umd.edu;
Wang Linfa <linfa.wang@duke-nus.edu.sg>; Hume Field <hume.field@ecohealthalliance.org>
Cc: Alison Andre <andre@ecohealthalliance.org>; Aleksei Chmura <chmura@ecohealthalliance.org>; Hongying Li
<li@ecohealthalliance.org>; William B. Karesh <karesh@ecohealthalliance.org>; Robert Kessler
<kessler@ecohealthalliance.org>
Subject: A Statement in support of the scientists, public health and medical professionals of China
Importance: High

Dear Ralph, Linda, Jim, Rita, Linfa and Hume,

I've been following the events around the novel coronavirus emergence in China very closely and have been dismayed by the recent spreading of rumors, misinformation and conspiracy theories on its origins. These are now specifically targeting scientists with whom we've collaborated for many years, and who have been working heroically to fight this outbreak and share data with unprecedented speed, openness and transparency. These conspiracy theories threaten to undermine the very global collaborations that we need to deal with a disease that has already spread across continents.

We have drafted a simple statement of solidarity and support for scientists, public health and medical professionals of China, and would like to invite you to join us as the first signatories. If you agree, we will send this letter to a group of around half-a-dozen other leaders in the field and then disseminate this widely with a sign-up webpage for others to show their support by signing up to its language. I will then personally present this at my plenary during the ICID 2020 conference in Malaysia in two weeks, with the goal of also getting widespread attention in SE Asia to our support for the work that our colleagues in China are undertaking.

I sincerely hope you can join us. Please review the letter, and let me know if you are willing to join Billy Karesh and myself as co-signatories. Also, please confirm your title and affiliation that will be shown in the letter. We plan to make circulate this widely to coincide with a letter from the Presidents of the US National Academies of Science, Engineering, and Medicine, which will likely be released tomorrow or Friday.

Thank you for your consideration and support of the scientific and public health community around the world!

Cheers,

Peter

Hi Peter,

The additional names of experts I suggest are those who have worked long term on CoVs:

1. Marion Koopmans, Erasmus Medical Center, The Netherlands
2. Bart Haagmans, same as above
3. Luis Enjuanes, National Center of Biotechnology, Madrid, Spain
4. Eric Snijder, Leiden University Medical Center, The Netherlands
5. Alexander Gubalenya, Same as above
6. Dr Mark Denison, Vanderbilt University, USA

Also I suggest Dr Yoshi Kawaoka, University of Wisconsin, USA

Regards,

Linda

Linda J. Saif, PhD
Distinguished University Professor
Food Animal Health Research Program
OARDC/The Ohio State University
1680 Madison Ave
Wooster, Oh 44691

From: Peter Daszak <daszak@ecohealthalliance.org>

Date: Thursday, February 6, 2020 at 10:25 PM

To: Linda Saif <saif.2@osu.edu>, Hume Field <hume.field@ecohealthalliance.org>

Cc: "JMHUGHE@emory.edu" <jmhughe@emory.edu>, Rita Colwell <[REDACTED]>
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Subject: RE: A Statement in support of the scientists, public health and medical professionals of China

Thank you very much Linda, Jim, Billy and Hume for signing on to this rapidly. Rita called today but was in a meeting and we haven't had time to talk, but I'll make sure we connect tomorrow.

Hume – I've taken some of your comments and lightly edited, and I've attached the revised version here. Linda – you're right it would be good to be specific about the bioengineered virus conspiracy theory, but we I think we should probably stick to a broad statement. The Presidents of the US National Academies of Science, Engineering and Medicine have drafted a letter that I expect will be released Friday or Monday. I've not seen the final version yet, but the draft version that we (and expert group that met last week) edited has the following sentence: "The initial views of the experts is that the available genomic data are consistent with natural evolution and that there is currently no evidence that the virus was engineered to spread more quickly among humans." I think this is a bit too specific, because there are other conspiracy theories out there.

Our current statement neatly refutes most of them by saying that "We stand together to strongly condemn conspiracy theories suggesting that 2019-nCoV does not have a natural origin. Scientific evidence overwhelmingly suggests that this virus originated in wildlife, as have so many other emerging diseases". Let me know if you want to change specific wording using 'track changes' above.

The plans now are to wait for Rita to give a Yes or No, then include a reference to the NASEM letter when that comes out, then circulate to some other eminent scientists. I've come up with an initial list below.

Please suggest names of your colleagues that you think might also be willing to support this (I'm sure some of these people are too busy right now to respond):

Dr. Rob Grenfell, Health Director, Commonwealth Scientific and Industrial Research Organisation (CSIRO)
Dr. W. Ian Lipkin, Professor, Columbia University

To: Linda Saif <saif.2@osu.edu>, Hume Field <hume.field@ecohealthalliance.org>

Cc: "JMHUGHE@emory.edu" <jmhughe@emory.edu>, Rita Colwell <[REDACTED]>
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Dr. W. Ian Lipkin, Professor, Columbia University
Dr. Christian Drosten, Professor, German Center for Infection Research
Dr. Juan Lubroth, Chief Veterinary Officer, Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations
Dr. Malik Peiris, Professor, The University of Hong Kong
Dr. Leo Poon, Professor, The University of Hong Kong
Dr. Keiji Fukuda, Professor, The University of Hong Kong
Dr. Jeremy Farrar, Director, The Wellcome Trust
Dr. Richard Hatchett, Chief Executive Officer, Coalition for Epidemic Preparedness Innovations (CEPI)
Dr. Richard Webby, Director, World Health Organization Collaborating Centre for Studies on the Ecology of Influenza in Animals and Birds
Dr. Peter Palese, Professor & Head, Dept Microbiology, Icahn School of Medicine, Mt Sinai Hospital
Dr. John Mackenzie, Professor Emeritus, Curtin University
Dato' Prof. Lam Sai Kit, University of Malaya
Dr. Stanley Perlman, University of Iowa, Carver College of Medicine
Dr. Larry Madoff, Editor, ProMED-mail

Once we've got a good group of around 20 well-known people, I will then circulate this via social media and email, with a link to a webserver for others in the greater science community (and interested public) to sign on to this statement. I will then present this to the ISID meeting in KL, Malaysia in 2 weeks and I think we'll get a big impact from that community and it should then take off.

Please note that this statement will not have EcoHealth Alliance logo on it and will not be identifiable as coming from any one organization or person, the idea is to have this as a community supporting our colleagues.

- Dr. Jim Hughes, Professor, Emory University -- **agreed**
- Dr. Rita Colwell, former Director of National Science Foundation -- **pending**
- Dr. Linda Saif, Distinguished University Professor, The Ohio State University -- **agreed**
- Dr. Billy Karesh, Vice President, EcoHealth Alliance – **agreed**
- Dr. Peter Daszak, President, EcoHealth Alliance -- **agreed**
- Dr. Hume Field, Honorary Professor, The University of Queensland – **agreed**
- Dr. Rob Grenfell, Health Director, Commonwealth Scientific and Industrial Research Organisation (CSIRO)
- Dr. W. Ian Lipkin, Professor, Columbia University
- Dr. Christian Drosten, Professor, German Center for Infection Research, Germany
- Dr. Juan Lubroth, Chief Veterinary Officer, Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations
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- Dr. Stanley Perlman, University of Iowa, Carver College of Medicine
- Dr. Larry Madoff, Editor, ProMED-mail
- From Kevin
- Dr. John Brownstein, Harvard University, HealthMap?
- Dr. Dennis Carroll, former USAID?
- Dr. Charles Calisher, Colorado State University
- Dr. Vincent Munster, NIH Rocky Mountain Laboratories
- Dr. Supaporn Wacharapluesadee, Chulalongkorn University
- From Linda Saif
- Dr. Marion Koopmans, Erasmus Medical Center, The Netherlands
- Dr. Bart Haagmans, Erasmus Medical Center, The Netherlands
- Dr. Luis Enjuanes, National Center of Biotechnology, Madrid, Spain
- Dr. Eric Snijder, Leiden University Medical Center, The Netherlands
- Dr. Alexander Gubalenya, Leiden University Medical Center, The Netherlands
- Dr. Mark Denison, Professor, Vanderbilt University, USA
- Dr. Yoshi Kawaoka, Professor, University of Wisconsin, USA
- From Jon
- Dr. Tony Schountz, Professor, Colorado State University
- Dr. Jonna Mazet. Professor, University of California, Davis
- Dr. Stephen Morse, Professor, Columbia University
- Dr. Christopher Broder, Professor, Uniformed Services University of the Health Sciences
- Dr. Marion Koopmans, Professor, Erasmus University Medical Center
- Dr. Ab Osterhaus, Emeritus Professor, Erasmus University Rotterdam
- Dr. Susan Lau, Hong Kong University?
- Dr. Charles Calisher, Emeritus Professor, Colorado State University
- Dr. Wanda Markotter, Professor, University of Pretoria

Dear All,

I want to thank you all for agreeing to act as a signatory on this statement of support for scientists and health professionals in China.

I have attached a final version of the statement that I will now circulate to a list of further proposed signatories (also attached). Once we have a sizeable number of these eminent public health scientists signing on to this statement, we'll then make it public and have a link to a webpage for people to sign in support.

As you can see, I added further references and text to this statement in response to really good comments from Rita Colwell. These include:

- 1) A reference to the GISAID webpage where 57 (to date) full genome sequences of 2019-nCoV from 12 countries are published and analyzed. This helps clarify that significant information has been made available to help people analyze the origins of this virus.
- 2) I've inserted a reference to the CDC webpage on 2019-nCoV which makes the following statement, completely in concurrence with our letter:
"2019-nCoV is a betacoronavirus, like MERS and SARs, both of which have their origins in bats. The sequences from U.S. patients are similar to the one that China initially posted, suggesting a likely single, recent emergence of this virus from an animal reservoir."
- 3) I've cited the statement from the WHO DG which was released today saying *"At WHO, we're not just battling the virus; we're also battling the trolls and conspiracy theorists that push misinformation and undermine the outbreak response."*
- 4) In addition, I've tried to make it clear that we will not be referring to this as a 'petition' but as a 'statement in support of' – This is in the title and will be in all materials we send out. This is to avoid the appearance of a political statement and make sure this is recognized as simply a letter from leading scientists in support of other scientists and health professionals who are under serious pressure right now.

Please let me know if anything further needs to be changed – I can do this before we release this publicly (probably by Wednesday or so this week).

Cheers,

Peter

Peter Daszak
President

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EcoHealth Alliance leads cutting-edge research into the critical connections between human and wildlife health and delicate ecosystems. With this science we develop solutions that prevent pandemics and promote conservation.